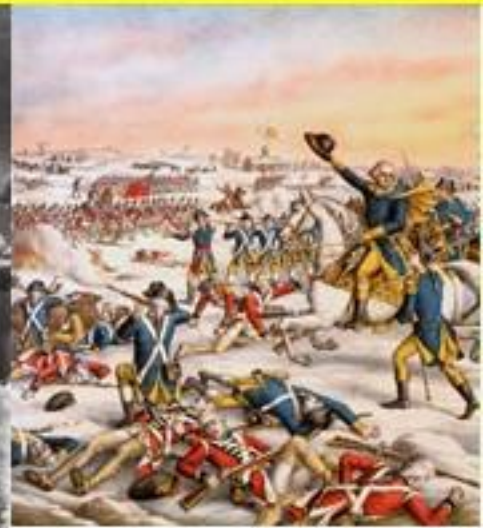


WORLD HISTORY



MODULE – 29

RUSSIAN REVOLUTION - 2

CIVIL WAR IN RUSSIA AND REIGN OF TERROR

a RED ARMY VS WHITE ARMY

1 The civil war was fought mainly between the Red Army, consisting of the uprising majority led by the Bolshevik minority, and the Whites- army officers and the bourgeoisie and political groups ranging from the far Right to the Socialist Revolutionaries who opposed the drastic restructuring championed by the Bolsheviks following the hijack of political power by Bolsheviks.

2 The whites had backing from nations such as Great Britain, France, USA and Japan, while the Reds sported internal, domestic support which proved to be much more effective.



CIVIL WAR IN RUSSIA AND REIGN OF TERROR

b BOLSHEVIKS

- 1** Like in case of Jacobians in French Revolution, Bolsheviks were also determined to preserve the outcomes of the Revolution at any cost.
- 2** Therefore, in order to suppress the counter revolutionary forces, they adopted terrorist methods.
- 3** Under the agency of tribunal “Chekha, those who were against the revolution were ruthlessly suppressed with iron hand.
- 4** There were thousands of executions in the name of preserving the spirit of the Revolution.
- 5** This brutal and ruthless suppression of the counter Revolutionary course completed the ruin and broke the spirit of old bourgeois class.
- 6** During this reign of terror, even Czar Nicholas II was not spared and he also became victim of the ruthless suppression by Bolsheviks.



CIVIL WAR IN RUSSIA AND REIGN OF TERROR

b BOLSHEVIKS

7 Despite, foreign intervention and their help to the counter revolutionaries, the Bolsheviks emerged as victorious in the civil war. The following are the reasons for their victory.

i SUPPORT FROM RUSSIANS

- Bolsheviks got the extensive support of the Russian workers and peasants who extended their full support to the new government as it has abolished the concept of private property.

ii DIFFERENCE OPINIONS IN COUNTER REVOLUTIONISTS

- The counter revolutionary forces were divided under various different ideologies like constitutionalist, liberals, monarchists etc. the friction was clearly visible between them and they lacked mutual trust and cooperation for joint action against Bolsheviks.



CIVIL WAR IN RUSSIA AND REIGN OF TERROR

b BOLSHEVIKS

iii NO PROPER FOREIGN INTERVENTION

- The foreign support and intervention was half-hearted. The allied countries like Britain, France, USA etc., were exhausted by the First World War.
- The issues like post war reconstruction of Europe, loss of population, heavy infrastructural damages in the war etc. compelled them concentrate on their internal troubles rather than supporting a foreign civil war.

iv WAR COMMUNISM

- In order to mobilize men and material for the war, Lenin took decisive measures, known as War Communism.
- Under this system all the resources of Russia were put under the control of the state. All factories were nationalized, all private trade was strictly abolished and surplus food and grains were seized from the peasants in order to feed workers and troops.



I ECONOMIC RECONSTRUCTION

- 1 After the success in the civil war, the next major task before the Bolsheviks was reconstruction of Russia.
- 2 The First World War and the Civil War has devastated the economy to a great extent.
- 3 Thus economic reconstruction of Russia was a herculean task.
- 4 The war communism imposed by Lenin had resulted into great dissatisfaction among peasants.

II ABOLITION OF PRIVATE PROPERTY

- Initially the peasants were in the favour of the revolution as the Bolsheviks abolished private property and peasants got rid of the oppressive feudal landlords.



III POLICY ON SURPLUS PRODUCTION

1 The surplus production by peasants were forcefully taken away from them with compensation under the system of War Communism the great way of dissatisfaction cropped up among them.

2 There was no incentive for the peasants to work hard and produce surplus grains beyond their personal consumption.

3 Thus they started producing the grain for their subsistence.

4 This caused acute food shortage that was aggravated by drought in 1920-21. In this famine about five million peasants lost their lives.



IV NATIONALIZATION OF FACTORIES

- 1 The conduction of production in the factories was no better.
- 2 The factory owners had to forcefully surrender their factories to the state which were nationalized.
- 3 The management of these factories passed into the hands of the Union of Workers.
- 4 These Unions lacked professionalism and capacity to successfully run the factories and workshops.

- 5 Hence the production in the factories went off diminishing which resulted into inflation.



V NEW ECONOMIC POLICY

- 1 At this critical juncture, Lenin realized the fact that it would be impossible to implement exact theory of Marxism in the context of Russia.
- 2 Thus he made various amendments in the original theory Marx so that it gets adapted to the ground realities prevailing in Russia.
- 3 He came up with New Economic Policy which compromised with various original theory of Marxism but practically solved various issues in Russia.



- 1** The following were the steps taken by Lenin under NEP for the reconstruction of Russia and to curtail agrarian distress.

CHANGES IN POLICY ON SURPLUS PRODUCTION

- Peasants were allowed to keep surplus after payment of tax. This tax was initially taken in the form of kind and later in cash.
- This was a compromise with the theory of Marxism which envisaged Nationalization of all means of production and production as per the need and not for profit.

RECOGNITION OF PRIVATE OWNERSHIP

- A similar compromise was made in context of small scale industries and trade where the private ownership was recognized.
- Though heavy and strategic industries remained state control.



2 Departure from Marxian Ideal:

- NEP was a departure from the Marxian ideal.
- It was a middle path between Socialism and Capitalism.
- Lenin was of the view that a temporary mechanism was essential in Russia to save the grains of the revolution.
- NEP was moderately successful: the economy began to recover gradually, NEP simulated the production and brought it to the pre-war levels.

3 The most significant aspect of NEP was the fact that it successfully solved to the issue of discontented peasants and brought production levels at par with the pre-war levels.

4 This gave ample time to Bolsheviks to consolidate the ideals of the revolution and do away with their enemies.



- 1** The establishment of the Bolshevik government in Russia evoked strong reaction in the western capitalist countries.
- 2** Bolshevik government urged the workers of the world to get united against the capitalists as a result western countries saw the Russian Revolution as the beginning of a world revolution against the capitalism and property rights. They were determined to crush the revolution at any cost.
- 3** The drastic deficit between the western countries and the Bolshevik government in Russia further enhanced when Russian government unilaterally withdrew from the war without consulting her war time allies.
- 4** Above all, the announcement by the Bolshevik leaders that they would not pay the foreign debts of the former government further instigated the western countries.



5 Allied powers aligned themselves with the reactionary and conservative forces in Russian Civil War.

6 It may be noted that the allied intervention in Russia began as a war measure against Germany, but speedily assumed the character of a domestic and foreign crusade against the revolutionary dictatorship.

7 By 1920 the allied effort to destroy Russian communism had failed.

8 On the other hand, the Russian ambition to bring about a world revolution also failed.

9 The revolutionary tendencies in Russia encouraged outbreaks in Germany and Hungary in 1919. But the same were quickly suppressed.



- 1 Russia withdrew from the First World War.
- 2 Later, formal peace was signed with Germany later.
- 3 The estates of the landlords, the Church and the Czar were confiscated and transferred to peasants' societies to be allotted to peasant families to be cultivated without hired labour.
- 4 The control of industries was transferred to committees of workers.
- 5 By the middle of 1918, banks and insurance companies, large industries, mines, water transport and railways were nationalised.



6 Foreign debts were refused and foreign investments were confiscated.

7 A Declaration of the Rights of Peoples was issued conferring the right of self-determination upon all nationalities.

8 A new government, called the Council of People's Commissars, headed by Lenin was founded.

9 These first acts of the new government began the era of socialism.



- 10** The first Soviet constitution was adopted on July 10, 1918.
- 11** It created the Russian Soviet Federated Socialist Republic.
- 12** Later, on December 30, 1922, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics came into being.
- 13** However, soon the new Soviet state was involved in a civil war.
- 14** The officers of the army of the fallen Czar organised an armed rebellion against the Soviet state. Troops of foreign powers—England, France, Japan, the United States and others—joined them.
- 15** War was fought till 1920. By this time the 'Red Army' of the new state was in control of almost all the lands of the old Czarist empire. Indeed, a revolutionary wave lasted until 1923.



QUESTIONS FOR PRACTICE

1. Describe the Bolshevik policy of war communism. What was it intended to achieve and how successful was it?

150 words

2. Was the New Economic Policy, passed by Lenin and his government in 1921, a strategic retreat?

250 words

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